

Word Count: 1000

Tiles

I only wait ten minutes before my name is called.

“James,” the nurse jumps.

I reply with a nod. Her eyes widened. She opens her mouth, lets it hang, then says.

“Come with me.”

As we walk, her hand scribbles a note. I’m guided down the hallway. Both of us are silent, save for the click of my heels and the squeak of her shoes. At the end, I’m brought to a small corner room.

“Do you have any COVID symptoms?” the nurse asks, pointing with her pen to the examination table. Her squeaking has turned to foot tapping. My clicks to crunching.

“No,” I lie, adjusting on the table.

“Alright, what brings you in today?” she asks without looking up.

I point to the left quadrant of my stomach. There’s a clear bulge. The contour of her chin gives it away. The gasp all but seals it.

“Ok, arms up, is that as high as you can go?” she proceeds. “You have a slight fever. 101.1,” she’s in a flurry, grabbing this and that, again, without looking up. At this point, she’s not even looking from where she’s grabbing her tools.

“Your heart rate and O2 are low.” The nurse says.

“Is that good?” I ask.

Do you work out?" She replies

"No," I mutter.

She finishes, returns her tools, and then turns to me. I've curled up like a pastry on wax paper. I'm still trying to sweat it off.

"Sorry," she says.

I lift my head. The corner of my eyes are wet. I turn red as her eyes catch mine, she grabs my wrist. The coldness of her fingertips makes me jump. Still, it's more familial than strange. After a strong squeeze, she lets go, stopping for a second before commanding,

"Wait here."

"Wait, what?" But it's too late. I'm left mouth open.

A breeze follows her out of the room. It smells and tastes of rose water. Before I can process what has happened, the doctor slides through the door.

"Hey there?" he looks at the nurse as he pulls up a stool.

I stare at him.

"Ah, alright then." He motions for me to show my belly.

"Tell me, sir, when—"

The nurse taps the doctor's shoulder. Nobody speaks as I stare at the two. She points at a note. The doctor tilts his head. I don't hear what is exchanged, because I have the strangest sensation of floating and sinking at the same time.

"Ah, well, my apologies," the doctor turns. "That, I mean, this is."

He rests the full weight of his hand on my shoulder. I try to stay perfectly still. I can hear his rolex ticking. Each crinkle of paper cracks my confidence. Every crunch is a clinical catastrophe. I space out for what must have only been a second.

“This is very urgent, Ma’am,” he reassures, “You need to take what I say very seriously.” he stops, waiting for me to confirm.

I nod in agreement. He glances at my abdomen. I put my hand over my belly. Still, something kicks from inside.

“It’s ok,” I say slowly, “Do I need to get a dog walker?”

Nothing.

“Right, how many hours is this going to take, roughly?” I try a new question.

The doctor and nurse look at each other. Then, they turn to me. I register only my reflection.

“So,” the doctor says, “we can’t diagnose this here.”

“Makes sense.”

“But this isn’t an hours-type of emergency.”

“Emergency?”

“Yes, emergency.”

I can smell the coffee on his breath. His stubble has already grown out.

“Do you want me to be direct?” he asks softly.

“You haven’t?”

“Alright, again, we can’t diagnose this.”

I keep nodding. He continues.

“This is most likely a tumor.”

“Makes sense.”

“Again, it is certainly a tumor, but,” he drones on and on.

I don’t think I’m supposed to be this calm. I think again while lying down. I catch the tail bits of some other conversation. Someone speaks.

“What do you mean?” I demand. “Who gets cancer in their early thirties?”

The doctor and nurse watch, waiting for whatever tidal wave this is to pass, but it doesn’t. It keeps rising and never crashes. It stays and sinks in while building up, until my thoughts flood.

My cheeks are warm now. I hear murmurs, not actual words. I do notice that the tiles on the ceiling are an absolute mess. Not one is properly aligned with the other. “Funny,” I think, as the light shines down my throat. All that because of one wrinkle in the corner. Then, the whole lot is off.

“Are you alright?” the nurse reaches out.

“Crunch,” the paper crinkles as my head hangs down.

“Right, so, how did you get here?” The doctor finally speaks to me. “Are you alone?”

“Listen, I walked in by myself, but I’m not alone.” I huff.

“Ahh, that’s good,” he says. “Otherwise we’d have to call an ambulance.”

There’s movement in my abdomen.

“No, it’s Monday morning, I’m not alone. I live,” He cuts me off.

“Right, well, we can’t let you walk out of here, especially since you came,” he points at the computer, grabbing the nurse’s attention while speaking.

“Methodist is five blocks away.” I protest.

“No, honey, you don’t understand. We already called an ambulance.” With that, the nurse is gone.

“For the Emergency Room,” the doctor says, rolling closer to me. “You needed to be there yesterday, and this is the best way to make sure you get seen.”

The nurse comes back with an office phone. The doctor begins dialing, muttering something to himself. The nurse has moved back to the computer, clicking away some message. I’m perfectly still, calm even until.

“Wait,” I say, motioning, “please stop” with my hands.

Shockingly, they do.

“I don’t have,” he cuts me off again.

“They already know you’re coming,” the doctor says.

“And right now,” the nurse looks me in the eyes, “your only job is not dying.”